

6.4 Home sweet homegroup

Homegroup is a new concept introduced in Windows 7 that makes sharing music, photos, videos, files and printers with other people on your home network easy and intuitive. You can now create a password protected home network in very few clicks without going through the hassle of setting up a network and fiddling with network configuration. You can even make your files ‘read only’ so that other people can access your content, but not change it. It's only available in Home Premium, Professional, and Ultimate variants of Windows 7.

If you remember what a headache it was to set up file and printer sharing in earlier versions of Windows, you'll be amazed at the difference a homegroup makes. During the process of setting up or joining a homegroup, you can choose the libraries and printers you want to share, and you are done. Even creating a homegroup is as easy as running a wizard.

6.4.1 Creating and joining a homegroup

To create a homegroup, open HomeGroup in Control Panel and then click on Create a homegroup. Your current network location must be set to “Home network.” That's because HomeGroup only works on networks having the Home network location. If you need to change the network location to Home from Work or Public, just click the current setting, and then pick it.

Computers must be running Windows 7 as a rule to be part of a homegroup (Windows 7 Starter and Windows 7 Home Basic only allows you to join a homegroup, but does not let you create one).

Setting your connection to Home for HomeGroups to work.

If you're installing

Windows 7 and you were already on a home network, a homegroup will be set up and joined automatically. You can join a homegroup by opening

